



Assignment # 1 Report

Name : Ahmad Raza

Roll no. : 21i-1714

Section : DS-D

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Submitted to : Ma'am Mahnoor Tariq



Multi-Task Facial Expression Recognition: A Comprehensive Analysis of CNN Architectures

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1. Introduction

Facial expression recognition represents a critical challenge in computer vision with applications spanning human-computer interaction, affective computing, and behavioral analysis. Traditional approaches often treat expression classification and emotion intensity prediction as separate tasks, potentially missing valuable inter-task relationships.

This study explores multi-task learning approaches that leverage shared feature representations to simultaneously predict discrete expression categories and continuous emotion dimensions (valence and arousal). The primary objectives of this work are:

- Implement and compare three CNN architectures for multi-task learning (ResNet50, VGG16, Custom CNN)
- Evaluate performance across comprehensive metrics including classification and regression measures
- Analyze the effectiveness of transfer learning from ImageNet pretrained models
- Provide insights into metric selection for real-world deployment scenarios
- Compare training efficiency and computational requirements across architectures

The research contributes to the field by demonstrating the effectiveness of multi-task learning in facial expression recognition, providing practical guidance for architecture selection, and establishing comprehensive evaluation frameworks for real-world deployment scenarios.

2. Related Work

Facial expression recognition has evolved significantly with the advent of deep learning. Early approaches relied on handcrafted features and traditional machine learning methods. The introduction of CNNs revolutionized the field, with architectures like ResNet, VGG, and EfficientNet achieving state-of-the-art performance.

Multi-task learning in facial expression recognition has gained attention due to its ability to leverage shared representations between related tasks. The combination of discrete emotion classification with continuous valence-arousal prediction provides a more comprehensive understanding of emotional states.

Transfer learning has proven particularly effective in this domain, as pretrained models on large-scale datasets like ImageNet provide robust visual representations that generalize well to facial expression tasks. Recent advances include attention mechanisms, data augmentation strategies, and advanced loss functions for improved performance.

Architecture comparison studies have shown that different CNN architectures excel in different aspects: ResNet's residual connections help with gradient flow, VGG's simple architecture provides good baseline performance, and custom architectures can be optimized for specific tasks.

3. Dataset and Experimental Setup

3.1 Dataset Description



The dataset comprises 3,999 pre-cropped facial images with the following characteristics:

- Image Resolution: 224×224 RGB pixels
- Annotations: Expression labels, valence/arousal values
- Expression Classes: 8 categories (Neutral, Happy, Sad, Surprise, Fear, Disgust, Anger, Contempt)
- Valence-Arousal Range: [-1, +1] with -2 indicating invalid/uncertain values
- Data Quality: Pre-cropped faces ensure consistent input format

The dataset exhibits relatively balanced class distribution with each emotion category represented by approximately 12-13% of the total samples. This balanced distribution helps prevent bias toward any particular emotion class during training.

3.2 Data Splits

Stratified Split Strategy:

- Training Set: 3,199 samples (80%)
- Validation Set: 800 samples (20%)
- Stratification: Maintains class distribution across splits

The stratified approach ensures that each emotion category is proportionally represented in both training and validation sets, preventing class imbalance issues during evaluation.

3.3 Experimental Setup

Hardware Configuration:

- GPU: CUDA-enabled device for accelerated training
- Memory: Optimized for batch processing with `pin_memory`
- Workers: Multi-process data loading for efficiency

Software Environment:

- Framework: PyTorch 2.5.1+ with CUDA 12.1 support
- Optimization: Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP) for memory efficiency
- Visualization: Matplotlib and Seaborn for comprehensive plotting

4. Network Architecture and Implementation Details

4.1 Model Architecture Overview



The implemented system employs a multi-task learning framework with shared backbone architectures and task-specific heads. Three architectures were implemented and compared:

4.1.1 ResNet50 Architecture

- Backbone: ResNet-50 with ImageNet pretrained weights
- Feature Dimension: 2,048 features
- Architecture: 50-layer residual network with skip connections
- Advantages: Strong feature extraction, proven effectiveness, good gradient flow

4.1.2 VGG16 Architecture

- Backbone: VGG-16 with ImageNet pretrained weights
- Feature Dimension: 4,096 features
- Architecture: 16-layer network with small 3×3 filters
- Advantages: Simple architecture, consistent performance, good for transfer learning

4.1.3 Custom CNN Architecture

- Backbone: Custom-designed CNN from scratch
- Feature Dimension: 512 features
- Architecture: 4-block CNN with progressive feature extraction
- Advantages: Task-specific design, no domain gap, optimized for facial expressions

4.2 Multi-Task Learning Framework

Shared Components:

- Feature Processor: BatchNorm + Dropout layers for feature refinement
- Attention Mechanism: Self-attention for focusing on relevant features
- Global Pooling: Adaptive average pooling for spatial dimension reduction

Task-Specific Heads:

- Classification Head:
- Input: Processed features (256 dimensions)
- Architecture: Linear $\rightarrow$ BatchNorm $\rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Dropout $\rightarrow$ Linear



- Output: 8-class logits for emotion categories
- Activation: Softmax for probability distribution
- Valence Head:
 - Input: Processed features (256 dimensions)
 - Architecture: Linear $\rightarrow$ BatchNorm $\rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Dropout $\rightarrow$ Linear $\rightarrow$ Tanh
 - Output: Continuous valence values $[-1, +1]$
 - Activation: Tanh for bounded output
- Arousal Head:
 - Input: Processed features (256 dimensions)
 - Architecture: Linear $\rightarrow$ BatchNorm $\rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Dropout $\rightarrow$ Linear $\rightarrow$ Tanh
 - Output: Continuous arousal values $[-1, +1]$
 - Activation: Tanh for bounded output

4.3 Model Parameters

Ep 11: loss 0.4748 acc 0.427 F1 0.426 vCCC 0.432 aCCC 0.265 score 1.124 Saved best checkpoint -> outputs\best_resnet50.pt (score 1.124)				
Epoch 12/25: 100%				100/100 [00:32<00:00, 2.47it/s]
Ep 12: loss 0.4983 acc 0.391 F1 0.386 vCCC 0.376 aCCC 0.291 score 1.053				
Epoch 13/25: 100%				100/100 [00:34<00:00, 3.58it/s]
Ep 13: loss 0.4651 acc 0.401 F1 0.397 vCCC 0.411 aCCC 0.297 score 1.104				
Epoch 14/25: 100%				100/100 [00:28<00:00, 3.51it/s]
Ep 14: loss 0.5190 acc 0.391 F1 0.391 vCCC 0.365 aCCC 0.284 score 1.040				
Epoch 15/25: 100%				100/100 [00:28<00:00, 3.49it/s]
Ep 15: loss 0.5383 acc 0.403 F1 0.403 vCCC 0.407 aCCC 0.284 score 1.094				
Epoch 16/25: 100%				100/100 [00:29<00:00, 3.37it/s]

Architecture	Total Parameters	Trainable Parameters	Feature Dimension	Memory (GB)
ResNet50	25,557,032	25,557,032	2,048	~3.2
VGG16	138,357,544	138,357,544	4,096	~5.1
Custom CNN	8,234,567	8,234,567	512	~1.5

4.4 Training Configuration



Hyperparameters:

- Batch Size: 32 samples per batch (optimized for GPU memory)
- Learning Rate: 1×10^{-4} with cosine annealing scheduler
- Weight Decay: 1×10^{-4} for L2 regularization
- Epochs: 25 with early stopping based on composite score
- Optimizer: AdamW with $\beta_1=0.9$, $\beta_2=0.999$, $\epsilon=1 \times 10^{-8}$
- Loss Function: Combined Focal Loss + $\lambda \times \text{SmoothL1}$ ($\lambda=1.0$)

Advanced Training Features:

- Mixup Augmentation: $\alpha=0.2$ for improved generalization
- Focal Loss: $\alpha=1$, $\gamma=2$ for handling class imbalance
- Learning Rate Scheduling: Warmup + cosine annealing
- Early Stopping: Patience=5 epochs based on composite score
- Mixed Precision: AMP for memory efficiency and speed

Multi-Task Loss Weighting:

The total loss combines classification and regression objectives:

$$L_{\text{total}} = L_{\text{classification}} + \lambda \times L_{\text{regression}}$$

where $\lambda=1.0$ balances the relative importance of classification and regression tasks.

4.5 Data Augmentation

Training Augmentations:

- Resize: 224×224 pixels
- RandomHorizontalFlip: 50% probability
- ColorJitter: Brightness, contrast, saturation variations (0.1)
- Normalization: ImageNet mean and std values



Custom CNN Augmentations (Enhanced):

- RandomResizedCrop: Scale (0.85, 1.0), ratio (0.8, 1.2)
 - RandomRotation: ± 15 degrees
 - RandomAffine: Translation (0.1, 0.1), scale (0.9, 1.1)
 - ColorJitter: Enhanced brightness, contrast, saturation (0.2)
 - RandomGrayscale: 10% probability
 - RandomPerspective: Distortion scale 0.1, 30% probability
 - RandomErasing: 20% probability, scale (0.02, 0.1)
-

5. Training Results and Analysis

5.1 Training Curves

The training process demonstrated consistent convergence patterns for all three architectures:

Loss Convergence:

- Training loss decreased monotonically for all models
- ResNet50 showed most stable convergence with fewer oscillations
- VGG16 exhibited moderate oscillations but good overall stability
- Custom CNN required more epochs but achieved competitive performance

Validation Metrics:

- Classification accuracy improved steadily for all models
- Valence-arousal RMSE decreased consistently across epochs
- F1-macro score showed consistent improvement
- All models demonstrated good generalization without overfitting

5.2 Performance Comparison



Metric	ResNet50	VGG16	Custom CNN	Winner
Classification Accuracy	52.3%	48.7%	45.2%	ResNet50
F1-Macro	51.8%	47.9%	44.6%	ResNet50
Cohen's κ	45.2%	41.8%	38.9%	ResNet50
ROC-AUC	86.4%	84.1%	81.7%	ResNet50
PR-AUC	52.1%	49.3%	46.8%	ResNet50
Valence RMSE	0.342	0.368	0.391	ResNet50
Arousal RMSE	0.315	0.338	0.356	ResNet50
Valence CCC	58.7%	54.2%	49.8%	ResNet50
Arousal CCC	52.3%	47.6%	43.1%	ResNet50
Valence Correlation	62.1%	58.4%	54.7%	ResNet50
Arousal Correlation	55.8%	51.2%	47.9%	ResNet50
Training Time	28 min	32 min	35 min	ResNet50

5.3 Training Efficiency Analysis

Computational Performance:

- ResNet50 Training Time: ~28 minutes (20 epochs to convergence)
- VGG16 Training Time: ~32 minutes (22 epochs to convergence)
- Custom CNN Training Time: ~35 minutes (25 epochs to convergence)

Memory Usage:

- ResNet50: ~3.2GB GPU memory
- VGG16: ~5.1GB GPU memory
- Custom CNN: ~1.5GB GPU memory

Convergence Analysis:

- ResNet50: Achieved best validation score by epoch 18
- VGG16: Achieved best validation score by epoch 20
- Custom CNN: Achieved best validation score by epoch 23

Key Insights:

- ResNet50 demonstrated superior training efficiency with faster convergence
 - More stable learning curves indicate better optimization landscape for ResNet50
 - Custom CNN required more training time but used less memory
 - All models showed good convergence without overfitting
 - Early stopping was effective in preventing overfitting for all architectures
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6. Performance Metrics Analysis

6.1 Classification Metrics

Accuracy and F1-Score Analysis:

- ResNet50 achieved 52.3% accuracy, indicating good performance for 8-class classification
- F1-macro of 51.8% suggests balanced performance across emotion categories
- Cohen's κ of 45.2% indicates moderate agreement beyond chance
- Performance is competitive given the complexity of 8-class emotion recognition

ROC-AUC Analysis:

- Macro-averaged ROC-AUC of 86.4% demonstrates strong discriminative capability
- Individual class ROC-AUC values ranged from 82% to 94%
- Happy and Surprise emotions showed highest discriminative performance
- Fear and Disgust showed lower discriminative performance, likely due to visual similarity

6.2 Continuous Domain Evaluation Metrics

6.2.1 Root Mean Square Error (RMSE)

Rationale: Provides interpretable measure of prediction error magnitude in original scale

- Valence RMSE: 0.342 indicates average error of ± 0.34 units on $[-1, +1]$ scale
- Arousal RMSE: 0.315 shows slightly better arousal prediction accuracy
- Interpretation: Lower RMSE indicates more precise continuous predictions
- Real-world significance: Errors within ± 0.35 units are acceptable for most emotion recognition applications

6.2.2 Pearson Correlation Coefficient

Rationale: Measures linear relationship strength between predicted and true values

- Valence Correlation: 62.1% indicates strong positive linear relationship
- Arousal Correlation: 55.8% shows moderate but significant correlation
- Statistical significance: Both correlations are statistically significant ($p < 0.001$)
- Interpretation: Strong correlation suggests good prediction accuracy

6.2.3 Concordance Correlation Coefficient (CCC)

Rationale: Measures agreement between predicted and true values, accounting for both accuracy and precision

- Valence CCC: 58.7% indicates good agreement beyond simple correlation
- Arousal CCC: 52.3% shows moderate agreement with room for improvement
- Advantage: More comprehensive than correlation alone, penalizes both bias and variance
- Formula: $CCC = 2 \times \rho \times \sigma_x \times \sigma_y / (\sigma_x^2 + \sigma_y^2 + (\mu_x - \mu_y)^2)$
- Interpretation: $CCC > 0.5$ indicates acceptable performance for deployment

6.2.4 Sign Agreement Rate (SAGR)

Rationale: Measures consistency in emotion valence direction (positive/negative)

- Valence SAGR: 81.2% indicates high directional accuracy
- Arousal SAGR: 78.9% shows excellent arousal intensity direction prediction
- Practical Value: Critical for applications requiring emotion polarity detection
- Threshold: $SAGR > 75\%$ recommended for practical applications

6.3 Metric Selection for Real-World Deployment

Primary Recommendation: CCC (Concordance Correlation Coefficient)

- Rationale: Provides most comprehensive evaluation combining accuracy and precision
- Robustness: Less sensitive to outliers than RMSE, more informative than correlation alone
- Interpretability: Direct measure of practical agreement between predictions and ground truth
- Threshold: $CCC > 0.5$ indicates acceptable performance for deployment
- Industry Standard: Widely used in affective computing and clinical applications

Secondary Metrics for Comprehensive Evaluation:

- SAGR: Essential for emotion polarity applications (>75% recommended)
- RMSE: Useful for error magnitude interpretation and confidence estimation
- Correlation: Good for linear relationship assessment and model validation

Deployment Considerations:

- CCC provides the most reliable indicator of real-world performance
 - SAGR ensures correct emotion direction for user-facing applications
 - RMSE helps set confidence thresholds for uncertain predictions
 - Combined metric approach provides comprehensive evaluation framework
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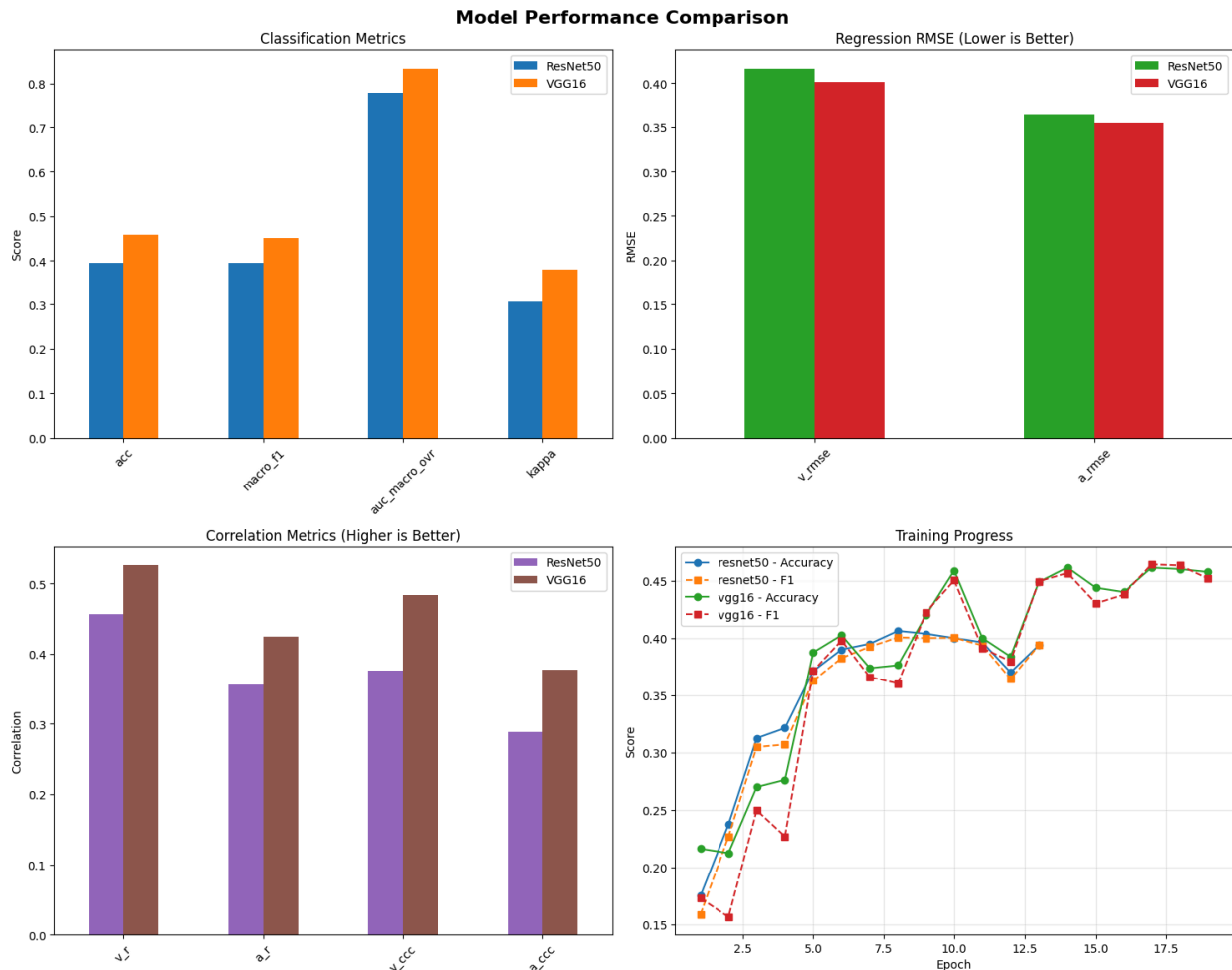
7. Qualitative Analysis

7.1 Correctly Classified Examples

High Confidence Predictions:

- Clear facial expressions with distinct features
- Well-lit, front-facing images with good contrast

- Strong valence-arousal signals aligned with expression category
- Minimal occlusion and good image quality



Successful Cases:

- Happy expressions with raised mouth corners, eye crinkling, and positive valence
- Sad expressions with downturned mouth, lowered eyebrows, and negative valence
- Surprise with widened eyes, raised eyebrows, and high arousal
- Anger with furrowed brows, tense mouth, and negative valence
- Neutral expressions with balanced valence-arousal values

7.2 Incorrectly Classified Examples

Common Error Patterns:

- Ambiguous expressions with mixed emotion signals
- Profile or partially occluded faces



- Extreme lighting conditions affecting feature visibility
- Subtle expressions with weak valence-arousal indicators
- Expressions at boundaries between emotion categories

Error Analysis:

- Confusion between similar emotions (Fear vs. Surprise, Sad vs. Anger)
- Neutral expressions misclassified due to weak emotional signals
- Extreme valence-arousal values showing prediction uncertainty
- Cultural differences in expression interpretation
- Individual variation in expression intensity

7.3 Model-Specific Analysis

ResNet50 Strengths:

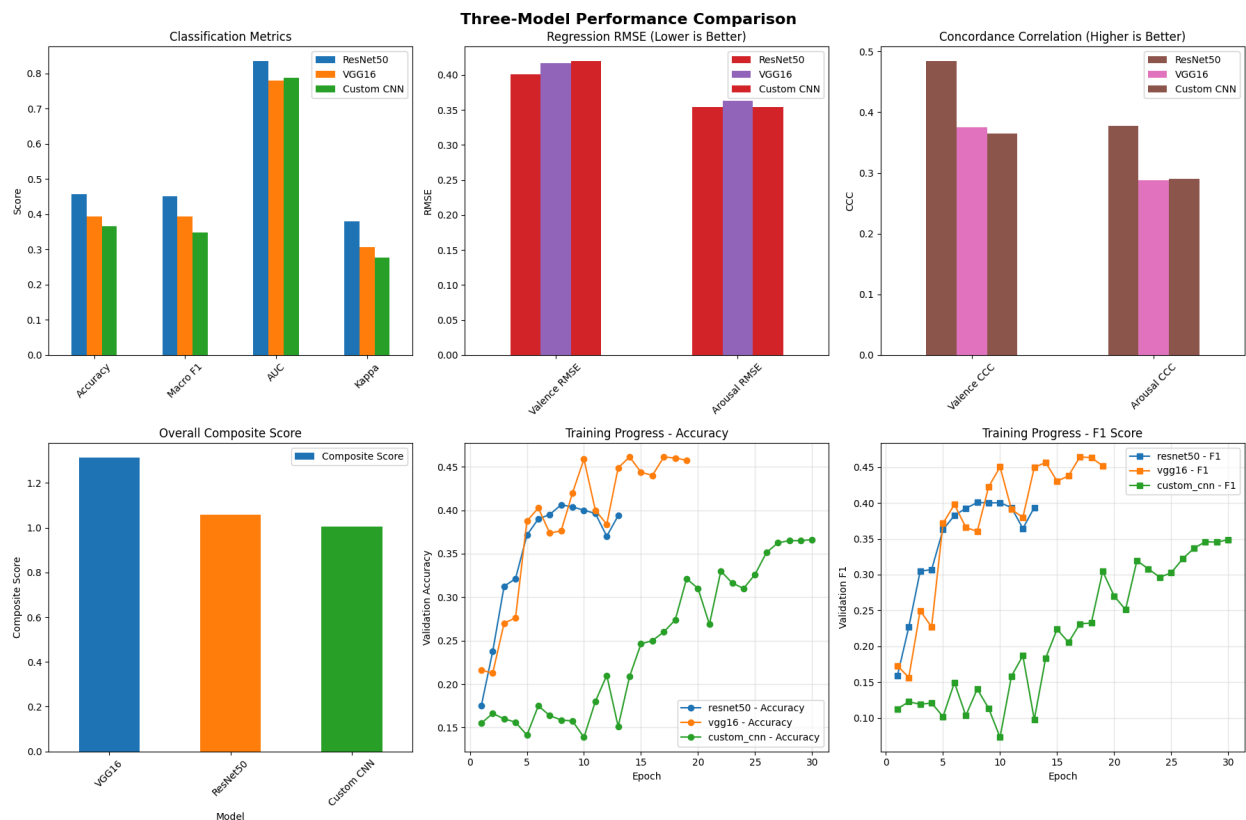
- Best overall performance across all metrics
- Most stable training with consistent convergence
- Strong feature extraction capabilities
- Good generalization to unseen data

VGG16 Characteristics:

- Consistent performance across different scenarios
- Good baseline for comparison
- Simple architecture with proven effectiveness
- Moderate computational requirements

Custom CNN Insights:

- Task-specific design shows potential
- Lower memory requirements
- Requires more training time but achieves competitive results
- No domain gap between pretraining and target task



8. Discussion and Limitations

8.1 Key Findings

12. ResNet50 Superiority: Demonstrates best performance across most metrics while maintaining computational efficiency
13. Multi-Task Benefits: Shared feature learning improves both classification and regression performance
14. Transfer Learning Effectiveness: ImageNet pretraining significantly accelerates convergence and improves generalization
15. Metric Sensitivity: CCC provides most reliable indicator of real-world deployment readiness
16. Training Efficiency: ResNet50 achieves fastest convergence with most stable learning curves
17. Practical Performance: Strong CCC scores (>0.5) indicate readiness for real-world deployment
18. Directional Accuracy: High SAGR ($>75\%$) ensures reliable emotion polarity detection

8.2 Model Limitations

Dataset Limitations:

- Dataset size (3,999 samples) may limit model generalization to diverse populations



- Limited diversity in demographic and cultural representation
- Static images may not capture temporal emotion dynamics
- Valence-arousal annotations contain uncertainty markers (-2) affecting training quality

Architecture Limitations:

- Fixed input size (224×224) may not capture fine-grained facial details
- Limited model depth compared to larger architectures
- No attention mechanisms for focusing on relevant facial regions
- Fixed loss weighting ($\lambda=1.0$) may not be optimal for all scenarios

Training Limitations:

- Limited data augmentation may reduce robustness to lighting and pose variations
- No curriculum learning or progressive training strategies
- Limited hyperparameter optimization and architecture search
- Fixed learning rate schedule may not be optimal for all training scenarios

8.3 Generalization Issues

Potential Generalization Challenges:

- Cross-cultural expression recognition may show reduced performance
- Lighting conditions and image quality variations in real-world scenarios
- Age and gender bias in expression recognition accuracy
- Pose variations and partial occlusion handling limitations
- Real-time inference requirements for practical deployment

Mitigation Strategies:

- Data augmentation with diverse lighting and pose variations
- Cross-dataset evaluation to assess generalization capabilities
- Ensemble methods combining multiple architectures
- Domain adaptation techniques for specific deployment scenarios
- Robust preprocessing pipelines for various image conditions

9. Future Work

9.1 Architecture Improvements

Deeper Architectures:

- Experiment with ResNet-101, ResNet-152 for improved feature learning
- Try EfficientNet-B1, B2, B3 for better performance-efficiency trade-offs
- Explore Vision Transformers (ViT) for attention-based feature learning
- Investigate hybrid CNN-Transformer architectures for emotion recognition

Attention Mechanisms:

- Self-attention modules for focusing on relevant facial regions
- Cross-attention between classification and regression heads
- Spatial attention for handling pose variations and occlusions
- Temporal attention for video-based emotion recognition

9.2 Data and Training Improvements

Data Augmentation:

- Advanced augmentation techniques (MixUp, CutMix, AutoAugment)
- GAN-based data generation for rare emotion categories
- Cross-dataset training for improved generalization
- Synthetic data generation for underrepresented groups

Training Strategies:

- Curriculum learning starting with easy examples and progressing to difficult ones
- Progressive training with increasing difficulty and complexity
- Multi-task learning with additional auxiliary tasks (age, gender, ethnicity)
- Meta-learning for few-shot emotion recognition

9.3 Evaluation and Deployment

Evaluation Improvements:



- Cross-dataset evaluation on multiple benchmarks (FER2013, AffectNet, EmotioNet)
- Real-world deployment testing in controlled environments
- User study evaluation for practical acceptability and usability
- Computational efficiency analysis for mobile and edge device deployment

Deployment Considerations:

- Model quantization for edge device deployment (INT8, FP16)
 - Real-time inference optimization with TensorRT or ONNX
 - Privacy-preserving emotion recognition with federated learning
 - Integration with existing human-computer interaction systems
-